

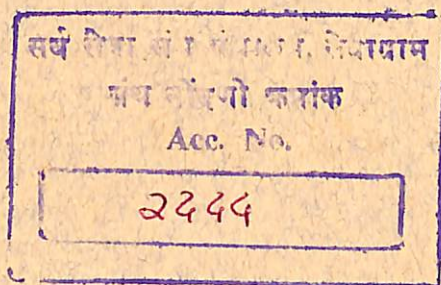
Bhoo-dan-Yajna

The

Great Challenge of the Age

by
DHIRENDRA MAZUMDAR

"Bhoo-dan-Yajna is the call of the hour. It is the voice of Destiny. It is, indeed, humanity's last chance, I hope our youth, in their thousands, will respond to the great call and work for the great fulfilment."



BHOODAN SAMITI, UTTAR PRADESH
SEVAPURI, BANARAS.

As. -/4/-

This is a small book by Dhirendra Bhai on Bhoo-dan-yajña. His thoughts on the subject are original. So is his presentation. Bhoo-dan-yajña is not going to be satisfied with a little relief to the poor. It stands for a change in the values of life. And on the basis of those values it aims at building up a new society which will be free from exploitation, and which, further, will progressively decentralize the administration with a view, ultimately, to attain complete statelessness. I hope that this attractive, though brief, treatise by Dhirendrabhai will help people comprehend Bhoo-dan-yajña in its original, undiluted, form.

—Vinoba
(Original in Hindi)

(1) THE PRICE OF FOLLY

It is a happy augury that Bhoo-dan-yajña has won the support of almost all the parties. The Communist party that has so far stood aside now appears to be more sceptical than inimical. Its doubts are that the Bhoo-dan-yajña movement does not go far enough. However, in spite of the communists' doubts and suspicions Bhoo-dan-yajña is already an all-party movement. But it is interesting that the author of the movement himself is one who is above party. Vinoba bears no affiliation with any party. He is like a high-priest trying to re-initiate us into the same mantra as Gandhiji taught us. He is restating the familiar Gandhian truths. The Bhoo-dan-yajña movement is, indeed, intended to complete the revolution which Gandhiji conceived and started. It is, therefore, proper that we examine afresh the ideological basis of this movement, as also the social order it visualizes and stands for. We must take care lest we should confuse mere land-distribution with Bhoo-dan-yajña and remain confined to the

sentimental aspects of the movement alone because in that case this new revolution may ultimately degenerate into a counter-revolution.

True Swaraj yet to come : Before we examine the fundamentals of the Sarvodaya revolution, let us first have a look at our country and the conditions that obtain in it at present. Let us see what its immediate problems are, and the consequences that will inevitably follow if they remain unsolved. It is certain that if we fail to bring about an economic and social revolution and build up a new social order we cannot avoid losing the freedom we have won. This was the warning that Gandhiji gave us, and we can ignore it only at our peril. Now, was this warning meaningless ? After all, the Swaraj that has come to us is by no means complete. It has yet to become the Swaraj of the millions that inhabit this vast country. Do they look upon this Swaraj as their own ? Our people live in the villages. The towns and cities represent but a fraction of the population. The celebrations of Aug. 15 are confined to the towns and cities only; they hardly touch the vast masses in the countryside. What, then, is the meaning of this Swaraj in terms of the millions except that we now have swadeshi raj in place of videshi raj ?

Gandhiji knew that this was so. Towards the end of his days he expressed his feelings to some of us in these words : 'The freedom that we have won is not true swaraj. It is not for you to run after power. Go and spread out into the villages and prepare the people there so that the swaraj that has come to Delhi may reach the remotest hut. Unless that is done swaraj in the real sense will remain unachieved.' But this clear warning of Bapu remained unheeded. We had our eyes fixed on the gaddis of power. In our eagerness to occupy them we ignored everything else. And those of us who could not get them remained to feel bitter or frustrated. Thus our swaraj has become a game of power-seeking, one group trying to overthrow the other and occupy the political gaddis. While the leaders fight for gaddis the people helplessly look on and suffer. We do not seem to care for what Gandhiji had said about resurrecting the villages. This complete neglect of the villages accounts for the ills with which we as a nation are suffering. The result is that the people are steadily being driven to desperation. Already there is a widespread whisper that British raj was better than this swaraj. What an irony of fate that people should prefer slavery to freedom ! But to those who know this should

cause no surprise. We are like swimmers who want to cross a river but who are so foolish that they stop swimming in midstream. We mistook political change for Swaraj, and stopped our struggle long before the end was reached. What surprise then that we are paying the price of our folly ?

(2) THE BASIC PROBLEMS OF OUR COUNTRY CLOTH

After five long years of trial and frustration Vinoba has now emerged to show us a way. Inspired by the last call of Gandhiji, he is wandering from village to village delivering the message of a new social and economic revolution. He is out to establish 'Gram-raj'. He has thrown out a challenge. He has also offered an opportunity. The key to the solution of the country's problems now seems to have been found.

What are our problems? How can they be solved? Obviously, the first problem is that of food and cloth. Food and cloth have become matters of life and death for the country. The question is so urgent that it brooks no delay.

Let us take cloth first. The problem of cloth can be solved in two ways : by Charkha plying in our innumerable cottages, or by mass-production in our mills and factories. The former is the way shown by Gandhiji, while the latter is the current way. We love Gandhiji ; we worship at his shrine, but we have no place for the Gandhian way. We swear by science, and so Charkha appears to us strange and foolish in this age of science. We seem to think that there is something in Charkha which is inherently unscientific. The thing is that we confuse science with technology. We do not give to politics, economics, psychology or sociology the same place as we give to technology. We fail to realize that a technique may be sound technologically, but it may be injurious to the best interests of the country if it disturbs the social and economic equilibrium of life in the country, or is otherwise unacceptable politically. Whether an instrument or technique is truly scientific is not determined technologically to the exclusion of all other considerations, but by the totality of the effects produced by it. That, truly speaking, is, and should be, the attitude of science.

The question of Capital : Let us examine in this light the question of producing cloth

by mills and factories on a centralized basis. For centralized production we need capital—enormous capital. Capital not in paper but in gold. Do we think that we have enough capital in the country? Ours, as we know, is an impoverished country. When the British left us they had already bled us white. It is a fact that our resources in capital are extremely limited. Will it be wise then to develop a technique of production that depends on capital? The story of the great Harishchandra should be a constant reminder of how, as a pauper, he had to sell himself for a few pieces of gold. Poor India will similarly have to sell herself if she goes about with hands stretched out for gold. And who will buy India? Obviously, America which possesses gold. The process, indeed, of India selling herself has already begun. It has taken us ninety years, from 1857 to 1947, to get rid of the British bayonet. How many years will it take us to throw off our heads the load of the American chests of gold? Let us not forget that economic domination is far deadlier than political domination.

Invisible Slavery : We know also how China, even when politically free, had actually been caught within the stranglehold of foreign economic domi-

nation. The economic slavery of China was invisible, while ours under British rule was political and visible. If we, therefore, run after foreign capital, we shall only be courting a new invisible slavery. It was for this reason that Gandhiji kept on reminding us that if we fail to revolutionise our system of production, i.e., adopt the decentralized in place of centralized production, we shall lose even the meagre freedom that we have achieved. Importing capital or goods or grains from outside is not going to help us. We must make our own land produce the things we need. We know that our millions are underfed; in fact, many go actually unfed. I often come across big posters bearing the slogan 'Grow More Food' pasted on the roadside or on the walls of railway stations. What do such posters suggest? Does food grow on paper? No, it can grow on the land in the villages and nowhere else. We must grow it there, and what we grow we must distribute equitably for the benefit of all. If we fail to do this, our freedom is in peril.

FOOD.

How to increase yield ? : The question is : how are we going to increase the yield of our land ? For one thing, the land at our disposal is limited. It cannot be stretched like rubber. Land being fixed and limited, what we need next is, (1) manure and water etc. by way of capital and, (2) labour. Produce depends on a wise combination of these two. So, if produce is to be increased, we must increase the amount both of capital and labour. For manure and water our government has undertaken vast projects. We hear of the Damodar Valley Corporation and a number of other big projects. There are talks even of harnessing the wind and controlling the clouds ! These are great projects requiring investment of enormous sums. But the question is, where is all the money to come from ? The ultimate source is the same : foreign aid. But let us not forget that every pie that comes from outside strengthens the bonds of slavery, though invisible. That is the inevitable result of our running after schemes beyond our power. Even

if we put aside these considerations for a moment and concede that this dependence on foreign resources is a necessary evil to be courted for the sake of our hungry millions, the question again is, how far, and how soon, are these plans going to help us? Will hunger and starvation wait till these schemes mature and start yielding the promised fruits? The danger is that by then the fire of hunger will have burnt the whole country to ashes. Who will then be left to enjoy the fruits of our carefully prepared plans? Our ghosts?

The need, therefore, is to be realistic. We must face the situation in a practical manner. It is time we stopped talking big. If we have to save the country we must immediately, and on the largest scale possible, make use of what resources are available in the villages—water, manure, animal power and manpower. But the resources of water and manure are again limited and are not capable of being increased quickly. In that case we must increase the labour applied to land. That is easy to do. We have labour available in plenty. The only thing to do is to change—and radically—the land-system and enthuse the labourer.

Land & Labour : It is a patent fact that because of the faulty land-system our land

is deprived of the full use of all the labour resources we have. Under the present system one who owns the land does not till it, and one that tills it does not own it. We all know that the land tilled by the owner himself yields more than the land tilled by hired labourers. Similarly, a labourer works harder on his own land than on the land not owned by him. Obviously, therefore, the owners of land must start tilling it themselves, and all land not self-cultivated must be transferred to those who have been working on it, but only as hired labourers. The actual tiller must now own the land he tills. He will then put forth his maximum effort and compel the land to yield much more than it does today.

(3) FREEDOM IN PERIL

Bhoo-dan-Yajna no Charity : Judged in this light Bhoo-dan-yajna is no mercy mission. It does not ask for charity. It is a programme conceived in the best interests of the nation. It will conserve not only our national interests, but it will protect the best interests of our landowners too. They should understand that Vinoba's call is not only for renunciation, but for self-preservation also, rightly understood. True, a good deed

brings its reward, but the reward or bliss is just an additional gain, not the main consideration.

Imagine a boat carrying passengers across a river. The boat, as we all know, is hollow inside in which the poorer passengers take their seats; the more respectable ones, usually better-dressed, sit on the planks attached to the side walls of the boat. In case there is a hole in the boat and water starts coming in, it is the people in the hollow who are the first to get wet. Those on the planks think that they are safe and need not worry about the water creeping into the hollow. But soon it becomes clear how foolish their self-satisfaction is. For, it will not take long for the water to reach them, and ultimately the boat will sink and all will go down together. In a situation like this, when one is faced with danger, it is no sacrifice to be forewarned and take suitable steps to save oneself. Will it be an act of philanthropy for the privileged passengers in the boat to part with the clothes they wear so that the hole in the boat could be closed and their lives saved? In fact what appears to be charity or self-sacrifice in such cases is really an act of self-preservation. Only that one should have the intelligence to understand where one's best interests lie. Let us understand that our freedom is in peril.

today. Possibly there are holes in the boat already. Even Nehruji has started warning us of western nations trying to stage a come-back to Asia. New chains of slavery are already being forged. Is it any wonder then that Vinobaji is warning us to take notice of the situation and act as prudent men before it is too late? He has detected the holes in the boat. The landless people in our midst are the holes. He wants the privileged among us to part with a portion of what they have in favour of those that have not. With these pieces of land in their possession they will do their best to produce more and feed the hungry millions, and thus ward off the danger of the flame of hunger setting the country on fire. And, if the country burns, will those who feel safe today be saved? That is why Vinoba's call is not for charity, but for the protection of oneself and one's own interests.

(4) TRUE SWARAJ

The other thing to know is that the swaraj we have got is not true Swaraj; it is mere Swadeshi raj. This raj is not going to solve our problems. We have yet to strive for true Swaraj. But the question is, how are we going to do it? Let us

first understand what true swaraj is. The swaraj that Gandhiji conceived is no-where to be seen in the world today. Not even in England and America. Some persons getting elected by what is called the free vote of the people is not swaraj. Real Swaraj lies in the power of the people to revolt against injustice and misuse of authority. So long as people lack this power they are bound to be exploited. And so long as there is exploitation democracy is not worth the name.

Man loves power : We must be clear on this point. People with faith in vote say that when people are conscious and awakened they will vote only for those who have proved their merit by selfless service and have won their confidence. If so, can there be any danger of such trusted representatives misusing their power ?, they ask. To this there can be but one answer. Psychologically speaking, man is innately fond of power. Once in power he will never voluntarily divest himself of it. Rather, he will try to add to it. His previous sacrifices make no difference to his innate weakness and love for power. This is so today in Kaliyug ; this was so in Treta, Dvapara and even Satyayug. And in this connection there is also an interesting Puranic story. We all know that Indrasana is attained after a long, long period of

hard penance. But once it goes to Indra, his first anxiety is how to retain it in his own hands for ever. He cannot even think of any one else qualifying himself for it. And in his anxiety to retain power what he does is not to increase his merit but to prevent others from competing by increasing their merit. He, therefore, tries to spoil their penance. It is not that Indra suddenly develops aversion for penance. How can he, having himself attained Indrasana as a result of penance? The question is simply one of power. Power is intoxicating. It intoxicates Indra, as it intoxicates everybody. The only difference is that our modern Indras use modern weapons. The ancient Indras sent 'apsaras'¹ to seduce the 'sadhaks'² away from penance. The modern Indras offer office ('afsari'³ instead of 'apsara') to win the good men over. The difference is one of technique only; the basic motive is the same.

Shiva and Tandava : This allusion has great lessons for us. It makes clear that in the ancient scheme of things while on the one hand Indrasana was considered necessary for government, on the other Shiva was

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1. Literally a sea-nymph ; a dancing girl.
 2. One engaged in penance.
 3. Lure of office.

considered equally necessary for the protection of the rights of the governed. With all his penance Shiva is one who never aspired for Indrasana. His duty was to remain watchful, and lead his band of 'ganas'¹ into 'tandava'² when necessary. Tandava was the final check on the dictatorial authority of Indra. It symbolized people's power to revolt against injustice and misuse of authority. What we lack today is a Shiva who could inspire us into tandava. Modern dictatorship is a direct result of the people's incapacity for tandava. Obviously, therefore, if the people of India wish to preserve their Swaraj they will have to cultivate Shiva's power of tandava, i.e. the power to rebel for the sake of their rights. In the absence of this power authority, howsoever benevolent, is bound to go wrong and ultimately become tyrannical. It is exactly in this sense that eternal vigilance is the price of liberty, and the capacity for tandava the test of democracy.

Conditions for tandava : But the question of all questions is, how is this going to happen? Mere desire for rights does not give one the power to win and preserve them. Along with desire conditions of life must be favourable, for only then, and not till then, can right

1. Followers. 2. Death-dance.

action lead to the desired results. Change is always the result of a right combination of 'prayatn' and 'paristhiti' (effort and circumstances). This law knows no exception. People love life and they love liberty, but when it comes to making a choice, they always choose life and forego liberty. The number of those laying down life for the sake of honour and liberty has always been small. Their names find place in the pages of history. People call them martyrs and honour them. But all the same, martyrs are rare and the common man, with all his admiration for the martyrs, never feels tempted to go the risky way. It is, therefore, as clear as anything that if the economic conditions are such in which the strings of people's life and liberty are held by the chosen few in authority, the chances are that people will not, cannot, rebel against authority's misuse of power. They will chafe; they will chagrin; at times there will be sporadic outbursts of discontent also; but ultimately people will bow down, or they will be cowed down. Inch by inch they will go on surrendering, till ultimately democracy will have died out only to yield place to dictatorship.

Nationalization no remedy: In the present structure of society it is capital that is the motive force and power everywhere. All pro-

duction is capital-centred. Not only in the economic but in other fields also it is the owner of capital (the capitalist) that dominates. It is thus that the capitalist class holds the strings of people's lives in its grip. It holds sway in the economic field ; it dictates in the political. It is the complete master of the social machine.

Some people say that if capital is nationalized society will be free from the clutches of the capitalist. Let us consider this. What is the difference that nationalization will actually make ? The only difference can be that both the economic and political power will be concentrated in the state instead of in the hands of the capitalist class. In place of private capitalism we shall have state capitalism and, therefore, state domination. And, however benevolent the state, it will not allow democracy to survive. Domination and democracy cannot go together. Coercion and consent are incompatible. Under state power, increased several-fold by the centralization of economic power, even formal democracy will disappear. Then, can there be Swaraj without democracy ? This explains why Gandhiji did not talk of nationalization, but of decentralization and self-sufficiency. He visualised and worked for an economy that would be labour-centred, and not

capital-centred. Labour-centred economy means that the means of production should be owned by those who actually labour on them. And if once labour replaces capital as the basis of economic life, the labourer will automatically replace the capitalist in the economic as well as in all other fields.

Bhoo-dan and one's interests. Land is the basic source of production. This being so, it should be owned by those who actually work on it. Unless this question is settled, there can be no real swaraj i.e. real democracy. And the key to the solution of our problems lies in the establishment of real swaraj. With our problems unsolved, and our country thrown into trouble, how can the landowning class alone remain unaffected? Can the land-owners isolate themselves? Since Bhoodan is a step in the direction of real Swaraj, it is not merely a cry for charity; it is, indeed, a call to the landowners to recognise their real interest and try to protect it by conceding the landless their due rights.

(5) HAJOOR AND MAJOOR

We must know that we are passing through a crisis. If we have eyes we can already see fires burning. All the world over the antagonism

between one class and another is every day growing more and more acute. What the result will be can easily be foreseen. Conditions in India are no better than in other countries. Our society is divided into two classes—one that sweats and produces, and the other that consists of middlemen and is, in a way, the broker class. The former may well be called 'majoor', and the latter 'hajoor'. The 'hajoor' live by exploiting the 'majoor'. How this exploitation goes on may be illustrated by an interesting story. The story of the monkey and the cats is quite familiar. The cats, as we all know, obtained a piece of bread. They could not divide it. They quarrelled among themselves. The monkey came forward to judge and arbitrate. So perfect and masterly was the monkey's performance that not a piece was left for the cats. Our 'hajoor' class is performing the functions exactly of the monkey.

Our Schools, Colleges and Universities, all hajoor-producing factories: The British rule in India accentuated and perfected the process and technique of exploitation. The British came to exploit us, but they could not have done so alone. So they created a partnership. They needed agents who could reach every village and every home. The 'baboo' among

us were only too willing to act as such. They were enlisted, but the number fell short of the requirement. How to produce more baboos was the problem. They hit upon a new educational scheme to do this. The ancient system of education in which the student lived with his Guru, earning his living and acquiring knowledge at the same time, and thus developing into full, self-reliant manhood, was scrapped and replaced by a new educational system so devised and worked as to produce baboos on a mass scale. Our schools, colleges and universities became nothing but baboo-manufacturing factories. They are really so perfect that after a few years' stay in them they turn even a labourer's son into a baboo. Our so-called educational institutions are not capable of doing anything else. Even to-day when the British have left we keep on multiplying these factories. The result is that the number of baboos has become so large that they themselves do not know where to go and what to do. Productive work is unknown to them. All that they are capable of doing is to exist as parasites and exploit others. Besides education, the ingenious land-tenure systems introduced during the British rule enabled our baboos to become owners of land and exploit the labourers. But the burden of

baboos has grown so heavy now that it is no more possible for the labourer to endure it. He must either shake off the burden or perish under its weight.

Hajoor & majoor both suffering : The situation created by the growing number of baboos is not happy even for themselves. The crisis is deepening day by day. Not that there were no baboos in the past. There they were, but their number was limited as compared to those who actually worked and produced. Exploitation then was easy and profitable. But now, since the number of exploiters has so enormously increased, it is no more possible for the 'hajoor' to feed fad upon the labour of the 'majoor'. There is not enough subsistence left for all the parasites. Our present society is so constituted that on the one hand the 'majoor' is being crushed under the the weight of the 'hajoor' while, on the other hand, the 'majoor' himself is withering away for want of enough subsistence. Already the situation is so alarming that if it continues unremedied for long, society will soon meet its inevitable doom. The exploiter class is like the sky-creeper that derives its nourishment from the tree on which it spreads, while the tree itself derives its sustenance from the soil. In the be-

ginning when the creeper is not full-grown we do not often mind its growing on the tree, but when soon it covers the entire tree we become anxious and cut it down so that the tree may be saved. The same thing is happening to the human society. Like the sky-creeper the exploiting 'hajoors' is sapping the life out of the 'majoor'. But how long will nature tolerate it? Nature is bound to eliminate the parasite for the sake of society. The dire threat to the producer at the hands of the parasite cannot be ignored.

(6) ELIMINATION OR ASSIMILATION ?

Our Revolutionaries : It is for this reason that the establishment of a classless society has become the cry of the age. But the question is, how is that society going to come into being ? There are two—only two—ways. One is for the 'majoor' to cut the throats of the 'hajoors' and thus exterminate them by violence so that there may be no 'hajoors' left in the world. The other way is for the 'hajoors' to become 'majoor' and get assimilated in the producer class. The former is the way of physical annihilation ; the latter is that of transformation. Which is the better solution ? Is the way of the sword better ? As things are, the

'majoor' is asleep and unconscious, while the 'hajoor' is awake and vigilant. The 'majoor' must be wide awake in order to take up the sword for a wider cause. But who will shake the majoor out of his slumber? Obviously, those who are already awake i.e. those of the 'hajoor' class who are able to see and understand things—ideologically conscious individuals. It is these individuals that have always provided the leadership of revolutions. But one sad experience of history is that these conscious individuals have put more faith in the philosophy of murder and the power of the sword. They have depended on, and made use of, man's propensity for revenge. They have not considered it worth while to teach the 'majoors' how to organize and manage their affairs and stand on their own feet when occasion comes. These 'revolutionaries' think that such activities are 'reformist' and foolish and delay the day of reckoning and take the edge off the people's revolutionary fervour. Therefore they talk of revenge and violence to the exclusion of everything else. They concentrate on first destroying the 'hajoor' class. But what happens when the 'hajoor' is exterminated? As soon as the 'hajoor' class is done away with, these self-same 'revolutionaries' start saying that since the 'majoors' do not know how to manage their

affairs, they (the hajoors) must continue to look after them. Thus they become self-appointed guardians ordained, as if, by destiny, to look after their wards, assuring them all the time that the guardianship would be withdrawn as soon as the wards become fit enough to stand on their own legs. But as always happens, the guardians never allow their guardianship to end !

Lesson of History : History in this respect has a sorely disappointing tale to tell. Whenever violence is resorted to in the name of revolution, the first cry of the revolutionaries is 'Raj of the people'. As soon as power comes, the slogan undergoes a change. From 'Raj of the people' it changes into 'Raj for the people'. And when the revolutionaries are firmly stabilized into power, and the new regime is free from danger, having eliminated all possible opposition, and the self-appointed leaders have succeeded in enlisting the support of some clever 'majoors', the 'hajoors' raise a new cry, that of 'Raj over the people'.

'Raj of the people'—'Raj for the people'—'Raj over the People', this is the succession of slogans that characterises the march of the revolution. The ultimate result is that power remains

in the hands of the 'hajoor' class, whatever new names it may assume.

Old wine in new bottles : It is not a question of the 'hajoor' being vile that they do not yield power to those to whom it rightfully belongs. It is essentially a question of man's innate tendencies. Scientifically, it is wrong to assume that a basic element can ever be destroyed. It can only change its form. Love of power is a basic tendency of human nature. In Russia the 'majoor' exterminated their oppressors, the 'hajoor'. The hajoor thus lost their existence as capitalists (punjipatis) but they reappeared in a changed form, as party bosses (dalpatis). In both the cases the 'hajoor' are there to sit tight on the chest of the 'majoor'—this time much more tightly than before. This is as it must be ; it cannot be otherwise. History is there to stand witness to this phenomenon of the old reappearing as new, both basically being the same. It is for this reason that murder and violence will lead us nowhere. In fact things will get much worse.

Violence no Solution : Violence does not, cannot, solve our problems. After all, what is it that we want a classless society for ? Is not peace in place of war and conflict our

goal ? In nature every action leads to a reaction. This goes on unceasingly. Accordingly, violence cannot but lead to counter-violence. In this process of violence and counter-violence what will be the point where we shall stop ? Where, and how, shall we break the chain ? It is time we learnt, as an inescapable lesson of history, that violence is impracticable, unscientific and futile. This way the fulfilment of our hopes does not lie. The alternative is clear. Violence should be abjured. The Gandhian way is the inevitable choice—the only one now left for humanity.

(7) THE GANDHIAN WAY OF CLASS TRANSFORMATION.

The way of **SHRAMA** : Gandhiji taught us a scientific way of class-transformation. He wanted that the 'hajoor' class (the bourgeoisie) should de-class and transform itself into the 'majoor' class. That is why he enjoined upon everybody to perform some productive bodily labour. He insisted upon spinning as the most universally available form of productive labour and denied one the right to use cloth unless one spun, and thus contributed towards its production. It was for this reason

that he introduced in Charkha Sangh the familiar yarn condition for purchasing cloth. Later, he enjoined upon the people of even such cities as Bombay and Calcutta to qualify themselves to eat by making some personal contribution in the form of actual labour towards the production of food-grains. When people said, "But where is land in Calcutta & Bombay?", he replied, "If there is no land, use earthen flower-pots". Obviously, Gandhiji could not have believed that offering of two pice worth of yarn for the purchase of khadi or growing a few plants in flower-pots could solve our national food or cloth problem. What he wanted was that each one of us should do his bit of productive labour and thus identify himself with the labourer and the producer and thus take one definite step towards declassing and the final merger of the classes. His further call to youngmen was that they should choose a life of productive bread-labour and settle in villages. He said that they would thus be creating a new labour leadership by becoming labourers themselves. He asked them to take up a comprehensive programme of village self-sufficiency in the basic necessities of life, and also in the sphere of internal management. The ultimate aim was to train the 'majoor' to be self-reliant so that he

could dispense with the 'services' of the 'hajoor'. For, after all, it is in the name of management, (vyavastha) and distribution (vitarana) that the 'hajoor' class justifies its social existence. It is this dependence on the 'hajoor' class that the 'majoor' must learn to dispense with. Only then can he stand on his own legs. This would also cut down the very roots of 'hajoor' leadership. The real thing is that the majoor must learn to say 'no' to the 'hajoor'. He must refuse to be exploited. Once such a situation is created, the 'hajoor' will find himself overwhelmed by the force and compulsion of circumstances. For him, then, there would be no choice but to yield, because he would know that the alternative to yielding was to perish. Faced with extinction the 'hajoor' is bound to take up the spade and till. As soon as he does so, he becomes a producer and the merger of the 'hajoor' and the 'majoor' becomes complete.

Nai Talim : There are two basic causative factors in a non-violent revolution: one is to create conditions whose compulsion becomes irresistible ; the other is to create proper understanding in the people. This combination of 'paristhiti' and 'pravritti' is absolutely essential for the success of a non-violent movement. It is in the light of this

basic fact that we should understand the Gandhian revolutionary technique. On the one hand he asked the 'hajoor' class for a change of heart (pravritti), and on the other hand he insisted upon a revolutionary change in the educational system of the country. He knew that while the old 'hajoor' would take time to change, it was necessary that all further addition to the 'hajoor' class must be stopped. He, therefore, wanted that our 'hajoor'-producing factories, i.e. the schools and colleges be closed and the old system of education substituted by Nai Talim. In Nai Talim productive labour is the basis and medium of education. This being so, the labourer's son in Nai Talim does not have to give up his vocation of productive work. He, in fact, learns through it. Besides, the 'bourgeois' child takes to production and by the time he goes out of school he is a fully transformed individual. Thus our next generation would, through Nai Talim, be fully transformed and consist of labourers alone--labourers who are not coolies, but are educated, scientifically trained and conscious producers. In this way would Nai Talim resolve the class-conflict and extinguish the volcano.

(8) VINOBA'S CALL : BLOOD OR MUD ?

Gandhiji is no more. But his teachings are with us. The way he has shown is open before us. While he was with us we failed to imbibe the revolutionary nature of his philosophy, much less adopt his technique of class-transformation. The result of our failure has been that we now find class-conflict sharper than ever. If we fail to resolve it without delay it is bound to end in disaster. Let us realize that it is against this background that Vinobaji has started his Bhoo-dan-Yajna movement. Vinoba's movement is a call and also a warning to the owners of land and property to divest themselves of the share that belongs to others. He wants this to be done here and now because the sands of time are running out. The urgency of the problem brooks no delay. "We are all children of the soil, Mother Earth belongs to all her sons. Let us not presume to be its lords. As children it is our duty to serve the mother. That means we have to work with our own hands. No more can our white clothes remain unsullied by earth. We must take to earth if we are to save ourselves." These are the words which, day in and day out, Vinobaji is dinning into the ears of the owners of property and land.

Blood or Mud : Choose : It is strange that

when we approach the 'hajoors' with this message of Vinobaji they get angry with us or laugh at us. They say: "Your Gandhi and Vinoba want to ruin us. They want us to become coolies. How can we give up our decent living, our neat white clothes, and take to this life?" They know not what they are saying. They seem to be ignorant of what is happening all round. But it is for us to awaken them; to make them conscious of the realities of the situation. We have to tell them that the times can no longer tolerate 'hajoors' sitting tight on the shoulders of the 'majoor's'. Class-conversion or class-conflict, we must choose one of the two. If we reject Vinobas' way of class-conversion, class-conflict is unavoidable. And once class-conflict starts our clothes can't remain white; in our vain attempt to avoid mud, we shall soon find that they have become red with blood. Surely, blood is more terrible than mud!

Let us, therefore, realize that Vinobas' movement is not merely for charity. It is conceived in the best interests of the 'hajoors' themselves. They must pause and ponder. Leaving aside all thought of charity and service, they must calculate in terms of profit and loss. The choice lies between blood and mud. Will not class-conversion be a better bargain?

Vinoba wants to save both Hajoor's and Majoor's : There are people who gibe at Vinoba and say that he is an agent of the 'hajoors' and his movement is meant to save the haves against the have-nots. No doubt, Vinoba wants to save the hajoors. Sarvodaya does not want to destroy anybody. It stands for the welfare of all. Vinoba is trying to raise the 'hajoors', as he is trying to raise the 'majoor's'. The 'hajoors', by living on exploitation, have fallen morally, whereas the 'majoor's' because of being exploited have fallen materially. By making suitable offerings in this Yajna the hajoors will gain morally, and having become free from exploitation the majoor's will gain materially. Vinoba is thus trying to save both the hajoors and the majoor's.

The world is sitting on the edge of a volcano. If we fail to realize the danger and leave things to nature, humanity is bound to meet its doom. Vinoba beckons us to be up and doing while there is still time. Shall we allow the world, already caught in a whirlpool, to be doomed ? Or, do we think that destruction is now inevitable, and must precede a new order ? Can we not, by our collective effort, redeem humanity and save it from annihilation ? These are the questions Vinoba asks and wants us to answer.

9. THE YOUTH MUST ACT

The youth of the country should understand that Bhoo-dan-yajña is a great challenge of the age. Will they accept the challenge, and devote themselves to it at least for a year? Or, will they sit still and wait for the volcano to burst? If they choose to remain unconcerned, let them know that history will never forgive them. The generations to come will curse us for our failure to respond to the call of the age. They will laugh at us and say that even with a prophet like Gandhi, and Vinoba as his great disciple, in our midst we could not save ourselves. How will the youth answer the charge of allowing their country, now politically free, to become economically dominated, or a dictatorship instead of a democracy? It will be said that if only they had not chosen to remain passive onlookers, the world could have been saved from the meshes of violence in which it was left to be caught.

I have faith in the good sense of our youth. I have no doubt that they will never let their fair name be dishonoured. Bhoo-dan-yajña is the call of the hour. It is the voice of Destiny. It is, indeed, humanity's last chance. I hope our youth, in their thousands, will respond to the great call and work for the great fulfilment.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Question. When you ask for land in 'dan', it means you concede that the Zamindars are the rightful owners of land. At the same time you say that 'all land belongs to Gopal'. How do you reconcile the two positions?

Answer. Dan does not mean charity. It really means equal distribution. Vinobaji has made this abundantly clear. Since all land belongs to Gopal, it clearly means that the tillers alone have a right to it. So, Vinobaji is demanding justice. He wants the present landowners to offer their land for equal distribution.

Q. Critics say that Vinoba's call is meant to prevent the future revolution. How far is this criticism justified? If it is, what chance is there for Vinoba's experiment to succeed?

Ans. Vinoba's movement is for revolution in the present, not in the future. World conditions, as they obtain today, cannot wait for a future revolution. Vinobaji has, therefore, started this movement with a sense of extreme urgency. Obviously, if the immediate revolution is rendered unnecessary, and if our problems

are solved in the immediate present, it is better for humanity that an imaginary revolution in the future is prevented. Why should it be asked to forego the present for the sake of an uncertain future? A revolution for the sake of a revolution is meaningless. It is welcome if it solves problems ; not otherwise.

Let one thing be clear. If a revolution is the demand of the age, no power can prevent it. Those who think of a revolution in the future believe that either the present conditions are not ripe for a revolution, or they do not know what a true revolution is. We cannot think of a revolution in terms of maxims written in text-books. A revolution keeps changing its mode and form from age to age. No two revolutions are exactly similar. But those who make criticisms of the type you mention here have in their mind some text-book picture of a revolution. It is quite understandable, then, that such orthodox people are unable to appreciate the revolution which Vinobaji has initiated. To those of you who are going to work for a just solution of the land-problem my appeal is that you should not depend upon old texts for a solution ; rather, you should study the objective conditions themselves and reach your own independent judgement. If

you do so you are bound to discover the revolutionary basis of the Bhoo-dan-yagñā. You will then see that the speed with which Vinoba's revolution is spreading in the country and outside was unattained by any other revolutionary movement in history. Can there be any doubt as to its success then ?

Q. Bhoo-dan-yagñā will take centuries. Can people afford to wait so long ? Why not press for legislation immediately, or work for a bloody revolution so that the problem may be solved without delay ?

Ans. Your question clearly shows that you are not able to get out of the old books you have read. I have just now said that no revolution in history has been so swift as this. Whatever method you adopt for land redistribution, the process is bound to end with legislation.

The question is, how is legislation to be brought about ? There are two ways. One is that you press the people in power to enact a law. The other is that you yourselves capture power and enact a law. Then, there are two ways of capturing power. One is the constitutional way through vote. The other is through an armed revolt. Both these methods have been tried in other countries. The technique of vote is most advanced in Britain.

You know that it took several years for the Labour Party in Britain to capture power. Still they fell from power even before they could consolidate it. We do not know how many more years the Labour Party will take to attain its objective. As against the Labour Party in Britain, the Communist Party in China tried war and violence. And it has not taken less than thirtytwo years even when the Nationalist Government of China had been badly mauled by the Japanese attack and the Civil Wars in China itself.

In contrast to both these look at the Bhoo-dan-yajna. It is only 3 years old. Don't you think that in the course of but thirtysix months ownership in land is already shaken to its roots? People are fast losing—or they have almost lost?—interest in the sale and purchase of land. Not that land has ceased to be what it has always been—man's most coveted possession. People not believing in the redistribution of land are already finding themselves out of tune with the times, and they feel compelled to change their views. They now admit that redistribution is inevitable. If the present pace of progress is maintained—and there is no reason why it should not be maintained—there is no doubt it will take less than five years for land to be redistributed. But if in any case you

are bent on legislation, you should feel satisfied that in this brief period the compelling power of Bhoo-dan-yajna has already begun to be felt by the people in power and also the members of the opposition, and that surely is a condition extremely favourable to legislation. If you, therefore, study Bhoo-dan-Yajna closely you will see that for a solution of the land problem it is the quickest of all the methods tried in history.

Q. For Bhoo-dan-Yajna you want the co-operation of all the parties. Even such persons have offered their services to it as are considered notorious by people. Do you think that with discredited persons working for it it can ever win the confidence of the people?

Ans. Sarvodaya believes in the 'udaya' (progress) of all. That means it stands for the purification of all. It is gratifying then, that, all kinds of people are participating in a programme of self-purification. The people do not care what the source of a movement is. But if a movement is of the right type, and is conceived in the best interests of the people, it will have its way, and a handful of people, howsoever bad, can't obstruct its progress. Rather, they will find themselves brushed aside by the onward rush of the movement. The water of the Ganga does not lose

its force or purity simply because the refuse of some towns mingles into it. This is borne out by daily experience too. When you go out to villages for 'safai' it is the bad odour that greets you first. Similarly, when you boil sugarcane juice dirt is the first to come up. In the great churning of the ocean poison appeared before nectar. Therefore, if you find that filth is coming up, rest assured the process of cleansing has well begun.

You know that Suras and Asuras had both joined in 'Samudra manthana'. It is well, then, that both are coming together in the Bhoo-dan-yajna. They are both bound to be purified, and what appears to be poison will ultimately turn into nectar. The process has already begun. Our different parties that looked upon each other as enemies are coming together as friends on the platform of Bhoo-dan-yajña. The gulf between the exploiter and the exploited has started being bridged. Do these facts not help you to overcome your doubts?

Q. Can your persuasion bring about total and universal change of heart? Supposing that this is possible at some stage, what will happen to those who are actually starving today during the period of waiting?

Ans. Not my words but the compulsion of circumstances will change people's hearts. There will be some people who will have wisdom enough to understand the hint of the situation ; there will be others who will be influenced by environment, and there will be still others who will yield to the irresistible compulsion of the changed circumstances. But till the final change takes place, the poor will continue to suffer as they are suffering today. This movement, you know, is intended to free them from misery. But can there be a movement which can show results even before it has succeeded ? Whatever measures you take, the poor will continue to be poor unless their poverty is removed. Take China. So long as the Communist Party was engaged in fighting, there was no improvement in the condition of the people ; rather, it deteriorated. It was bound to. The Bhoo-dan-yajña movement is better than other movements in so far as during its course the condition of the people does not deteriorate. It cannot be worse than what it is today even if we assume that the movement is not going to succeed. Not that it will not deteriorate; it will, in fact, improve because, after all, whatever land, is received in gifts will be distributed to the poor.

Q. In so far as Bhoo-dan-yajna movement or such other movements bring about decentralization of the means of production, they will injure the interests of one class. Will this be Sarvodaya? Sarvodaya stands for the good of all, not of one class!

Ans. I have already explained that the centralization of the means of production is bound to result in mass-exploitation of the people. When there is exploitation in society, it will affect both the exploiter and the exploited. One will fall morally, the other materially. Bhoo-dan-Yajna will raise the exploiter morally and the exploited materially. Who will then lose?

Q. Neheruji and other ministers in several states issue appeals in support of Bhoo-dan-Yajna. All this means that they have faith in the ideals of Bhoo-dan. But if they are sincere, why do they not enact laws for the redistribution of land? Vinobaji commands influence with the Government. Why does he not use the official agency for suitable legislation, instead of wandering from place to place asking for gifts of land?

Ans. So far as legislation is concerned, the question should better be addressed to the Government itself. May be, they are not yet sure about the reaction a law for land-distribution will

produce in the country. They may be afraid of opposition on a large scale. If that is so, they are right in waiting for a suitable atmosphere before they take to law-making. But I can only guess. What actually prevents them, they alone know. Why Vinobaji does not ask for law is a question I can answer.

Bhoo-dan-Yajna does not end with mere redistribution of land. It is in fact the beginning of a total revolution. The goal is the establishment of a social order free from all exploitation. Exploitation is not only economic; it is also moral and spiritual. Even the state is an instrument of exploitation if it robs people of their freedom. The more we are dependent on this instrument, the less free we are. Therefore, complete freedom is possible only in a stateless society.

There are two social forces in the world — Dandashakti (power of the rod) and Janashakti (power of the people). Now, for a stateless society it is necessary that we eliminate Dandashakti altogether. Also, that we make a beginning by trying to solve our social problems by Janashakti alone, because reliance on Dandashakti will vitiate our attempt.

From this point of view the attempt of Bhoo-dan-Yajna to solve the land problem by

Janashakti is a unique experiment. If success comes, a very great step will have been taken in the direction of statelessness. After this first success it will be comparatively easy to apply Janashakti to the solution of other problems; nay, to the whole field of social organization. We may not all at once eliminate Dandashakti altogether, but our dependence on it will progressively diminish. That is why we are not relying on Dandashakti for the success of this movement which, we hope, will educate our people in the conviction that it is not only theoretically possible to avoid Dandashakti to a large extent, but it is practicable also. This belief and confidence will give our people the strength to take further strides on the road to statelessness.

Q. You as well as other people of your way of thinking talk of a stateless and classless society. The Communists too aim at establishing a similar society. What, then, is the difference between Sarvodaya and Samyavad.

A. Vinobaji uses the term 'Samyayoga'. The difference between 'yoga' and 'vad' is the difference between the two principles, Samyavad and Samyayoga. 'Vad' means principle. It stands for an ideal and an outlook on life. But 'Yoga' is practice here and now.

The Communist does talk of a stateless society but his practice is wholly opposed to his profession. In his hands the state becomes a far mightier instrument of coercion while all the time he keeps on saying that in the last stage the state shall wither away. The last stage we can but imagine; it can hardly ever, or perhaps never, be realized. It is for this reason that to me the Communists' statelessness is no more than a fond dream; a Utopia never to be realized. In practice it is just the opposite : government with ever increasing powers. As opposed to Samayayoga, Sarvodaya in the very first step tries to do without the coercive power of the state as far as possible. Its practice begins with its profession. Every succeeding step means progressive statelessness. It is obvious, therefore, that Samayayoga and Samyavad are two different things altogether.

Q. You ask even those who have small pieces of land to offer their share in Bhoodan. How, do you think, will they maintain themselves if they part with the little they have?

Ans. Just as the landless labourers do. By giving away land they also become landless. Their problem will ultimately be solved along with those who are landless today. But there is a difference. Those who are landless today are so because they

cannot help being so, but those who give away all the land have become landless by choice. By deliberately giving away land they derive moral satisfaction. They become soldiers of the new revolution. They become one with their landless brethren and, as such, spread the message of the revolution. By asking the poor to offer their land in 'dan' Vinobaji is only recruiting soldiers for his army so that his movement may gather force and speed. It is necessary that our landless labourers today develop this revolutionary strength. If they fail to do so, they are bound, in the conditions as they are, to take to the path of violence. Our labourers are not conscious. They cannot discriminate. They do not have enough judgement. They cannot distinguish true revolution from false revolution. And once they take recourse to violence, the whole world will be caught in a whirlpool of violence and counter-violence.

Q. Even if you succeed in distributing land without using the coercive power of the state, how will those who get it protect it?

Ans. Imagine land being redistributed through non-violence. What a revolution it will be! And then will it not generate tremendous power in the Kisans? And, can't they protect the land

they get with the new power they develop? It is for this reason that Vinobaji lays so much stress on the organization of people's power (Janashakti). The organization of Janashakti automatically leads to complete transference of the means of production to the hands of the producer and with it comes the power to protect it.

Q. If it is correct to say that with a new power developing in the Kisans, they will be able to protect their rights and property, why did the Kisans in Telangana yield to the government the land they had once forcibly occupied?

Ans. The failure of the Telangana Kisans clearly shows that they had not developed their power. They had occupied the land, not by their power, but by the power of the communist guns. The guns of the government proved stronger than the guns of the communists, so the government forced the Kisans to yield the land. It is a fatal mistake to imagine that guns can organize Janashakti. Contrary to this, guns rob the people of their power. What wonder, then, that the Kisans, when faced with government violence, found themselves helpless.

Q. On the one hand you talk of revolution through Bhoodan and on the other the landlords are ejecting the bataidars and the Shikmidars.

Don't you think this makes more and more people miserable? What do you propose to do in this connection?

Ans. You cannot avoid this in the beginning. The tyranny of Kansa increased with the birth of Krishna. And this is usual. Whenever a revolutionary movement is born, its opposite reactionary tendencies become more vicious than before. But this phenomenon need not worry us. With the revolutionary Krishna in her arms, Yashoda did not feel perturbed at the presence of Kansa. What she did was to take more and more care of Krishna. She gave him butter and other nutritious foods so that he could develop full strength. Vinobaji is doing the same thing. He is exhorting youngmen to give at least a year's time to Bhoo-dan-yajña so that the movement could develop rapidly and achieve its aim of delivering the country.

Our experience is that wherever there are workers to organize Bhoodan work the problem of ejection is easily solved because they make the people understand the situation. The one course, therefore, to stop this trouble is for workers in large numbers to spread out into the villages and counteract the reactionary tendencies.

Q. You don't approach the big landlords also-

ne. You ask small landholders also for land. Why? They are already poor. Why make them poorer?

Ans. In a yajna everybody should make his offering without which the yajna will not be successful. The revolution will not gather force unless our countrymen welcome it and co-operate with it. We ask even the landless for 'dan'. Let them offer 'shramadan' and join the revolution.

Secondly, in a non-violent revolution psychological change is more important than mere material change, as the latter will not last long unless preceded by the former. The question does not end with the divesting of the landowners of their land: they must also give up their attachment for land. Attachment for land is common with both who own land and those that have none. Hence our appeal to both. They both have to learn that Mother Earth is not to be owned. They can only till the land and reap the fruit of their labour.

It has often happened in history that by the time a revolution has reached the last stage of its full and final success, counter-revolutionary forces have combined and overwhelmed it. The result is that the revolution itself becomes counter-revolutionary. In the case of Bhoodan, therefore,

unless the people develop a psychology favourable to non-ownership of land, merely divesting them of land will not take us far. Their psychological hunger for land will take the form of hunger for authority, and thus a new counter-revolutionary force will be born. And that will take us to dictatorship instead of democracy.

Q. Often people donate usar, waste and uncultivated land. Why do you accept such land?

Ans. Could the donor of such land have allowed anybody to occupy it before Bhoodan? People fight for every inch of their land, good or bad. The owner is attached to all his land, irrespective of its quality. So, a gift of land means also renunciation of attachment for land, however limited in extent. And this adds to the very necessary psychological preparation for revolution.

When you sat for examination, while at school, you must have answered the easier questions first, and the stiffer ones afterwards. Similarly with renouncing land. The bad pieces of land must go before the good ones are finally yielded with the progress of the movement. We are now actually getting good land.

Q. Land in our country is already badly fragmented. Bhoo-dan will lead to further fragmentation. Fragmentation adversely affects produc

tion. - How then do you say that Bhoodan will lead to increased production?

Ans. Your knowledge about agriculture is fifty years out-of-date. The latest researches in agriculture show that small holdings lead, not to diminished production, but to increased production. you must have read about the latest experiments in England, Japan and China.

People in these countries have greatly increased production by cultivating small plots. Vinobaji gives a family five acres. In Japan a family has only three acres. And their progress in production is unrivalled in the world ! You possibly know that ploughs do not operate on about 80% of the land in Japan. In place of ploughs Kudal and small implements alone are available for tilling. In the face of these experiments, and in a number of countries, it is idle to talk of small holdings affecting production for the worse.

Similarly, to say that Bhoodan will further fragment the already fragmented land in India is incorrect. Whoever gifts land gives a whole plot, never a portion of it. It has also happened that when in a village a number of donors gift land they often choose their plots for gift at the same site. Thus they make it possible for the gifted pieces to be put together.

Q. Your goal is the establishment of a stateless society, but you have just said that the ideal state is like the point in Geometry. That means that in Sarvodaya too the state will be there. If so, what is the proper place of state in Sarvodaya ?

Ans. It is true that statelessness is the ideal state. I have, therefore, purposely talked of only comparative deliverance from 'danda' (danda-nirpekshata). This means that even if the 'danda' is there, its use will not be necessary in the day to day business of the society. Not Dandashakti, but Janashakti will be the guiding force in the life and social organization of the people.

In Sarvodaya Samaj the selfsufficient village unit will be fully developed. In this state of village self-sufficiency the state will be a coordinating agency. It will preserve society from disintegrating just as in a garland the thread holds the fully-bloomed flowers together. The thread itself is not visible; the flowers alone are. The moment the thread is visible, it is a sign of the garland withering. In a country of self-sufficient village units the state will be required like the thread, to hold the units together and keep the nation and society united. Such a state will not impose itself upon the people. If it does so, know that it is a signal for decline and decay.

Popular Bhoodan Literature

(English & Hindi)



- १—संत विनोबा और भू-दान-यज्ञ—विनोबा जी
- २—संत विनोबा की उत्तर भारत यात्रा—दामोदर दास मुँदड़ा
- ३—भू-दान प्रश्नोत्तरी—विनोबा जी
- ४—भू-दान-यज्ञ युग की महान चुनौती—धीरेन्द्र भाई
- ५—अगला कदम—दादा धर्माधिकारी
- ६—मानवीय क्रान्ति— ” ”
- ७—Bhoodan Yajna (English)
- ८—सम्पत्ति दान यज्ञ
- ९—सर्वोदय (मासिक), वर्धा
- १०—भूदान यज्ञ, बिहार (साप्ताहिक), पटना
- ११—भूदान (साप्ताहिक), बनारस
- १२—Sarvodaya (monthly), S. India.

By the same author

- १—स्वराज्य की समस्याएँ
- २—यह स्वराज्य कैसा ?
- ३—स्वराज की असली लड़ाई
- ४—क्रान्तिकारी चरखा
- ६—नयी तालीम
- ७—समग्र ग्राम-सेवा की ओर

ENGLISH :

- 8—The Demand of the Times
- 9—The Revolutionary Charkha

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